

headphones that lack it as well, like the Sony WF-1000XM5. However, there are headphones cheaper than these that have an IP rating. So, for my occasional encounters with sudden showers of rain, or for use in the gym, it would be ideal that these headphones pack a basic IP certification. Splash resistance would be enough.

Moving on, to the performance of these headphones.

PERFORMANCE

If you have read my article about the winners of the Digit Zero1 and Best Buy Awards 2023, then you would know how the JBL Tour One M2 performed in our tests. As you can see in the graph below, the sound profile of these headphones out of the box, in the typical JBL fashion, is on the warmer side, with a subtle boost to the lows. However, unlike other JBL headphones, where the bass tends to eat into the mids and the highs, sounding muddy, in the Tour One M2, it has been managed fairly well.

These headphones sport a nice V-shaped sound signature, with the highs being boosted and managed well to balance out the lows, and the mids come close to our reference flat sound signature recorded using pink noise. This meant that the headphones were suitable for most genres of music and would provide a great listening experience out of the box. In our test suite, we have tracks like Uptown Funk by Bruno Mars, Rescue Me by OneRepublic, and Skyfall by Adele, and I could barely find points to complain about when listening to those tracks.

The latency when consuming content or playing games was minimal as well. So, no complaints there. Be it dialogues in movies or the thump of the bullets in games, all the sounds were reproduced well by these headphones. At ₹19,999, these headphones close in on the territory where a lot of audiophiles would also have an eye out for a pair of headphones they would daily-drive, ideally with a flatter sound than that of the Tour One M2. However, I am comfortable with recommending these headphones to audiophiles and purists who prefer a flat sound signature. The reason is that the drivers of these head-

phones are tuned well, and you can also change the sound signature of these headphones as you like using the app. So, if someone prefers a flatter sound signature, then they can easily get it by changing the software level settings, and the hardware will keep up with the changes. I tried it out myself and here are the results. With some tweaking, you can get a flat sound from these headphones if you are someone who likes it that way.

As of the microphone, I had no problems taking calls in the office, or outside in a noisy environment. In some cases where there was a whole lot of noise, then it crept in and the receiver had problems comprehending what I was saying for brief moments. However, that should not be an issue, because that happened very rarely, and I had to put myself in extremely specific scenarios to be able to replicate those results. For day to day use, these headphones do the job well.

The ANC on these headphones also matches up to what one would expect when shelling out ₹19,999 on a pair of headphones. The isolation provided by the headphones adds to the overall effectiveness of the ANC on these headphones. In some notably noisy environments, there were a few instances of background noise filtering through. However, overall, the headphones performed admirably. Their active noise cancellation (ANC) proved superior to all other headphones tested this year at the Center, effectively eliminating nearly all ambient noise, with only occasional instances of sudden, sharp noises managing to seep through.

BATTERY LIFE

JBL claims that these headphones can last 30 hours with ANC turned on. And, with ANC off, the number goes up to 50 hours. In my testing, I found these headphones to clock in 28 hours with volume set to 50 per cent and ANC turned on. Not bad at all. However, we have seen headphones like the Sennheiser Momentum 4 Wireless packing a battery that lasts well over 50 hours. So, if you are someone who is looking for that extra bit of battery life, you might want to look away from the JBL Tour One M2.

However, if you are fine with the 28 hour battery, then you can definitely get these headphones. You also get a claimed 5 hours of playback after only 10 minutes of charging time, so that is a bonus. And these headphones support both wired and wireless playback. So, in crunch moments, AUX to the rescue!

VERDICT

The JBL Tour One M2 hold their ground well and make for a great pair of headphones in their own right. They sound well out of the box, have great build quality and fit, and are decked out in terms of features as well. They were the best pair of headphones launched this year, and make for a great purchase at ₹19,999 or below, in case their price drops during sales. The sound of these headphones leans on the warmer side, out of the box, but can be tweaked using the app, and the comfort and features that these provide, is something that make these an instant recommendation from me under the 20K price bracket.

However, if any thing from these headphones is not to your liking, then you can go for either the Sennheiser Momentum 4 Wireless or the Sony WF-1000XM5. Both these headphones are priced above the JBL Tour One M2, but are worth the extra penny you would spend on them. With the Momentum 4 Wireless, you get better battery life, with slightly weaker ANC in my opinion, and with the 1000XM5, you get one of the best ANC headphones in the market right now, well rounded with features and a great sound signature.

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Driver size (mm): 40 | Number of Microphones: 7 | Driver sensitivity at 1kHz/1mW (dB): 117 dB SPL@1 kHz | Dynamic frequency response range (Hz): 10 Hz - 40 kHz (passive), 10 Hz - 22 kHz (active) | Impedance (ohms): 32 | Earpiece Weight (oz): 9.6 | Earpiece Weight (g): 278 | Bluetooth version: 5.3 | Charging time (hours from empty): 2 | Maximum music play time with ANC off (hours): 50 | Maximum music play time with ANC on (hours): 30 | Maximum play time (hours): 50

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